

The Unlucky Billionaires' Trifecta from Hell

HAVE YOU EVER heard of the Belfers? They are a great American immigrant success story. But contained within this family narrative are a few examples of how easily things can go off the rails. This is true even for the most financially successful people.

After learning of the Belfers' amazing story—a generous family who despite all of their setbacks, are doing just fine today²⁴⁹—you will have a much better understanding of why avoiding mistakes is so much more important than actively chasing the nonsense Wall Street is selling. It is also a reminder that it is not just you or me, but *everyone*—including billionaires—who make money mistakes.

If only we made better decisions, we would all be so much better off.

Arthur Belfer and his family lived in Kraków, Poland, where he worked as a dealer in feathers and down. He came to the United States over the summer of 1939, with a few *zlotys* in his pockets. Between the time his ship left Europe and arrived in America, Germany invaded Poland. As the Blitzkrieg advanced toward Warsaw, Belfer's wife and children escaped, joining him in New York City months later.

The *zloty* had been the official Polish currency since 1528, giving Poland four centuries of stable money. But once the Nazis rolled over the border, the Polish currency Belfer held in his pockets became suddenly worthless. Penniless, he set about rebuilding his life in New York City, while waiting for his family to arrive. He did what he did best: Selling down and feathers. Despite being broke, he found a New York broker to import feathers from Europe for him, which he then resold at a profit.

Thus was born the Belfer Corporation.